other seriously overpaying.' It added, referring to this acquisition, that 'the idea of a winner's curse has rarely seemed more apt'.

As the end to the bidding was nowhere in sight, the UK Takeover Panel put Corus under the hammer. On 26 January, the panel announced that if a 'competitive situation' continued to exist at 4.30 p.m. (GMT) of 30 January 2007, the final bid would be decided by an auction. The first eight bids would be on fixed prices and the last one either on a fixed price or a bid calculated by a reference to a formula.

The highest offer until then had been CSN's 11 December bid of 515 pence per share. It promised to be a tense face-off. 'Backed by a hot-to-trot Goldman Sachs, CSN's Benjamin Steinbruch is determined to have Corus, almost regardless of price,' wrote *The Independent*.

Assessing Right

Tuesday, 31 January 2007, promised to be an exciting day for the Tata Group. It was when the biggest-ever single investment decision in its history would be taken. It was the appointed day for the conclusion of the auction to decide the new owners of Corus.

On 30 January, the Tata Sons board met at 11 a.m. at Bombay House to discuss the strategy for the next day. The meeting was attended by ten directors, including Ratan. The members also comprised Nusli Wadia, Hussain, Irani, Muthuraman and Tridibesh Mukerjee. Besides, Soonawala and Chatterjee attended by invitation.

The board meeting got over only towards the evening. Thereafter, Ratan and a small group of his most trusted lieutenants proceeded to the Taj, Mumbai, which they had made their battle station. They had come prepared to be there past dawn the following day. As the clock ticked past midnight in India, even the occasional lights of cars making their way through the deserted road became scarce. Only the waves breaking into a soapy froth were visible in the luminance of the streetlights from the room.

Some 7,000 km northwest in London, another battle station was set up in the less-dramatic setting of the offices of law firm Herbert Smith at Broadgate. It was from there that Arun Gandhi, who had been handpicked to implement perhaps the most important component of Ratan's strategy for expansion—inorganic growth through mergers and acquisitions—and Sandip Biswas, Tata Steel's head of treasury, would oversee the auction